



lineup has often haunted its opponents.

This time was no different, as Mumbai showcased its batting prowess, bolstered by a cadre of all-rounders.

Despite the absence of Dube, its top all-rounder, who had made significant contributions in the league stages, Mumbai's batting remained formidable.

Players like Shardul, Kotian, Mulani, and the emerging talent of Musheer demonstrated their mettle.

In the quarterfinal against Baroda, Mumbai found itself in a precarious position at 142 for five. However, Musheer's double century propelled it to a total of 384 in the first innings. Remarkably, in the second innings, Kotian and Deshpande rewrote records by scoring centuries while batting at No. 10 and 11, respectively.

The semifinals showcased Mumbai's batting depth once again. Chasing Tamil Nadu's modest total of 146, Mumbai stumbled at 106 for seven. Yet, Shardul and Kotian's resilient partnership added 272 runs,

setting up an emphatic innings win.

In the final against Vidarbha, Mumbai faced a similar challenge, but Shardul's aggressive batting salvaged the innings, doubling its total to 224.

Mulani and Kotian then contributed with both bat and ball, building on Musheer's impressive hundred in the second innings.

Mumbai's wealth of genuine all-rounders proved invaluable.

L for leader

Throughout the tournament, Rahane's struggles with the bat became a major talking point. But his resilience shone through, culminating in a classy innings of 73 in the final, his best of the season. However, his overall tally of 214 runs in 13 innings, at an average of 17.83, was far from impressive. For someone with 85 Test caps, such a dip in form could have warranted a break or even led to a loss of interest.

Yet, Rahane displayed exceptional character by separating the responsibilities of captaincy from his batting woes. His determination to

Leading from the front: Ajinkya Rahane shrugged off his poor form with the willow to win his fourth Ranji Trophy title as a player and his first as captain. EMMANUAL YOGINI

lead his team to victory, securing his fourth title as a player, served as a driving force, showcasing his unwavering commitment to the team's success.

"The moment I got out, I switched into the role of being the captain," Rahane told Sportstar as a matter of fact.

"There are times when you don't score; you just have to take it in your stride and not let it affect your role as captain, and more importantly, not pass it on to the team."

Rahane never allowed his personal frustrations to affect his interactions with other players. Instead, his teammates acknowledged his active involvement as a motivating factor that spurred them on to achieve glory.

Captains are not made; they are born, after all!